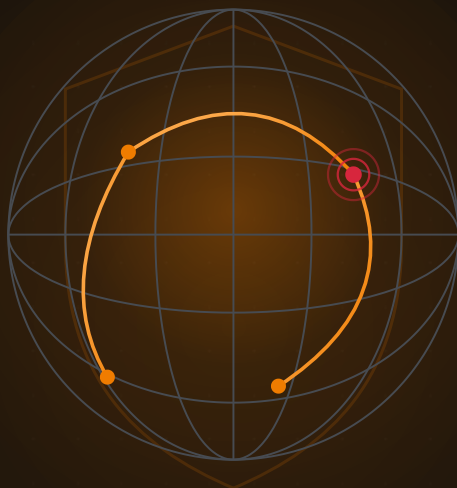




THREAT PULSE

WEEKLY CYBER THREAT BRIEFING

WEEK IN REVIEW · 17–23 AUGUST 2026

Inside this week: a **China-linked ransomware campaign** exploiting core virtualisation software across 47 countries, a **critical VPN gateway flaw** businesses should patch before it's exploited, and a claimed **3.6-million-record breach** at household-name companies — explained in plain English, with the practical steps that matter.

Welcome to **Threat Pulse**, your plain-English weekly round-up of the cyber threats making waves around the world — and what they mean for your business. This week a **China-linked group used a critical flaw in widely used virtualisation software** to break into organisations across 47 countries and deploy ransomware, a **VPN gateway flaw** needs patching before attackers catch on, and a claimed breach put **millions of employee records** from household-name companies up for sale. No jargon, just what happened and the practical steps worth taking.

AT A GLANCE THIS WEEK

⚠️ **9.8** /10

Severity of the VMware vCenter flaw being used to deploy ransomware worldwide

✓ **47**

Countries with confirmed victims of the vCenter attack campaign so far

📦 **3.6** M

Employee records claimed stolen from Fortune 500 cloud accounts this week

THIS WEEK'S HEADLINE THREAT

VMWARE VCENTER SERVER • CVE-2026-59310

A critical flaw in widely used virtualisation software is being used to plant ransomware



CRITICAL

Exploitation: **active & in the wild**

WHAT'S HAPPENING

VMware vCenter Server — the console many organisations use to manage their virtual servers — has a critical flaw that lets attackers take **full administrator control without logging in**. A suspected China-based hacking group has been exploiting it since early August, planting backdoors for lasting remote access and, in many cases, deploying ransomware that encrypts everything it can reach. The US cyber agency CISA added it to its **actively-exploited list**, and researchers have already confirmed victims across **47 countries**.

WHO'S AFFECTED

Any organisation running its own **VMware vCenter Server** (self-managed versions 9.1, 9.0 or 8.0 before this month's fixes). vCenter is the control panel behind virtual server environments used by mid-size and larger businesses of almost every kind — if you or your IT provider run virtual servers on VMware, this is worth checking today.

WHY IT MATTERS TO YOU

vCenter sits at the heart of your virtual server environment. A break-in here can mean attackers seizing **your entire server infrastructure** — not just one machine — and encrypting it for ransom. There is **no cloud-hosted version** that patches itself automatically; protection depends entirely on you or your provider applying the fix.

Good news if you don't run VMware vCenter: businesses that host everything with a public cloud provider (rather than running their own VMware environment) aren't directly exposed. It's still worth a quick check with your IT provider, who may run vCenter behind the scenes on your behalf.

! What to do about the headline threat

- ✓ Ask your IT team or provider whether you run **VMware vCenter Server**, and if so, confirm it's updated to the **latest fixed version** today — there is no other workaround.
- ✓ Because attackers' backdoors can survive a routine patch, ask them to also **check for signs of compromise** — unexpected admin accounts, unfamiliar scheduled tasks, or unrecognised remote-access tools.
- ✓ If vCenter is reachable from the public internet, ask that it be **restricted to trusted networks only** while patching is confirmed.

OTHER THREATS WORTH KNOWING ABOUT



HIGH

A critical flaw in a popular VPN gateway needs patching now

Citrix disclosed a critical flaw (CVE-2026-19490) in **NetScaler ADC/Gateway** — appliances many businesses use to give staff secure remote access — that can let an attacker **skip the login screen entirely** under some configurations. No confirmed attacks yet, but researchers expect that to change fast given this product's history.

Takeaway: if you use Citrix NetScaler for remote access, patch it now — don't wait for confirmed exploitation.



HIGH

A code-hosting flaw was attacked within minutes of disclosure

A flaw in self-hosted **GitLab** (used by many businesses to store their software source code) let attackers with no login tamper with company code repositories. Security researchers reproduced a working attack within **minutes** of the fix being published, and real attackers followed almost as fast — an unusually short window between disclosure and abuse.

Takeaway: if your business or developers self-host GitLab, update to the latest version immediately.



MEDIUM

Millions of employee records claimed stolen from cloud accounts

A hacker claims to be selling **3.6 million employee records** allegedly taken from the cloud accounts of major companies including McDonald's and Vodafone — reportedly via guessed passwords and “MFA fatigue” (bombarding staff with login approval requests until one is accidentally accepted). Some named companies dispute the claim, so treat it as credible but unconfirmed.

Takeaway: switch to phishing-resistant MFA (number-matching or a hardware key, not a simple tap-to-approve) so a tired employee can't accidentally let an attacker in.

★ Your 3-minute checklist this week

- ✓ Confirm any **VMware vCenter** environment is patched to the latest version and not exposed to the public internet (see previous page).
- ✓ If you use **Citrix NetScaler** for remote access, patch it now — don't wait for confirmed attacks.
- ✓ If you self-host **GitLab**, update to the latest patched version immediately.
- ✓ Move away from simple tap-to-approve MFA where you can — it's the weak point attackers are actively targeting.

Threat Pulse is provided by DPG-Cyber for general awareness only and does not constitute specific security or legal advice. Threat details are drawn from reputable public reporting as at 24 August 2026 and may evolve as investigations continue. For guidance tailored to your environment, please contact your DPG-Cyber account team.

BEHIND THE HEADLINES

Why a **watchful eye** changes the outcome

Every threat in this issue had one thing in common: the damage happened in the **quiet gap between the break-in and the moment someone noticed**. Tools alone rarely stop an attack — what limits the harm is continuous monitoring that correlates the signals, spots the intrusion early, and responds before a foothold becomes a crisis.

247 days

Average time for organisations to identify *and* contain a breach

SOURCE: IBM COST OF A DATA BREACH 2026

\$4.99M

Global average total cost of a single data breach

SOURCE: IBM COST OF A DATA BREACH 2026

THE WINDOW THAT MATTERS

Intrusion
the way in

Foothold
quietly settling in

Lateral movement
spreading across systems

Impact
data theft / ransomware

↑ The sooner an attack is spotted, the smaller the damage. Closing this window — detecting and responding on the left, long before impact on the right — is the entire job of a Security Operations Centre.

WHAT CONTINUOUS MONITORING QUIETLY DOES



Sees across everything

A SIEM gathers and correlates activity from across your systems, so unusual behaviour stands out instead of hiding in the noise.



Watches around the clock

Attacks don't keep office hours. A SOC means real people monitoring day, night and weekends — not just 9 to 5.



Knows the latest tactics

Fresh threat intelligence — like the appliance and supply-chain attacks in this issue — feeds detection so new tricks are recognised fast.



Acts, not just alerts

Alerts are triaged and investigated by analysts who step in early, turning a would-be incident into a non-event.

CLIENT ACTION OF THE WEEK

THIS WEEK'S FIX

Check and patch your VMware vCenter Server

If you or your IT provider run **VMware vCenter**, confirm this week that it's updated to the latest fixed release — attackers are actively using the flaw to plant ransomware, and there's no other workaround.

GOOD HABIT

Switch on phishing-resistant MFA

Where you can, move from simple tap-to-approve MFA to **number-matching or a hardware security key**. It closes off the "MFA fatigue" trick attackers used in this week's claimed Fortune 500 breach.

This is the quiet, everyday work behind **DPG-Cyber's SIEM & SOC services** — the same monitoring and response that turns headlines like these into non-events for the businesses we look after. If you're ever curious how it would map to your own environment, we're always happy to talk it through, no pressure — just drop us a line at hello@dpg-cyber.com.